



ETHICS REVIEW PROTOCOL SUBMISSION FORM FOR SUPERVISED AND SPONSORED RESEARCHERS

(For use by graduate students, post-docs, and visiting professors/researchers)

Request for a Delegated Review:

We believe this study represents minimal risk to participants and the researcher for the following reasons (elaborated in the complete submission form, below).

Full disclosure of the purpose and methods of this study are presented to prospective participants during recruitment; the participants to be recruited are post-secondary students and instructors in post-secondary institutions (therefore not specifically members of vulnerable communities); the data elicited during the interview process are non-invasive and non-compromising; anonymity of participants is ensured; participation requires minimal time and inconvenience on the part of participants. Interviews will be conducted at a distance through Internet-based communication.

For these reasons, we request consideration for this protocol to receive a delegated review.

SECTION A – GENERAL INFORMATION

1. TITLE OF RESEARCH PROJECT

An Ethnography of Classroom Designs in Second Life and Other Immersive 3D Virtual Learning Environments

2. INVESTIGATOR INFORMATION

Investigator:

Title: M. A. Student	Name: Daniel Fekete
Department (or organization if not affiliated with U of T): CTL, OISE	
Mailing address: 33 Appian Dr., Toronto, ON, M2J 2P8	
Phone: 647 654-7396	Institutional e-mail: danny.fekete@utoronto.ca

Level of Project

Faculty Research ☐	CBR/CBPR Research ☐
Post-Doctoral Research ☐	
Student Research: Doctoral ☐ Masters ☒	Student Number 996613883

Faculty Supervisor/Sponsor:

Title: Professor	Name: Clare Brett
Department (or organization if not affiliated with U of T): CTL, OISE	

Mailing address: 11-134, OISE, 252 Bloor St W. Toronto, M5S 1V6		
Phone: 416 978-0123	Institutional e-mail: clare.brett@utoronto.ca	

Co-Investigators:

Are co-investigators involved? Yes ☐ No ☒

Title:	Name:	
Department (or organization if not affiliated with U of T):		
Mailing address:		
Phone:	Fax:	Institutional e-mail:

Title:	Name:	
Department (or organization if not affiliated with U of T):		
Mailing address:		
Phone:	Fax:	Institutional e-mail:

Please append additional pages with co-investigators' names if necessary.

3. UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO RESEARCH ETHICS BOARD:

Health Sciences ☐ Social Science, Humanities and Education ☒ HIV REB ☐

Please consult <http://www.research.utoronto.ca/for-researchers-administrators/ethics/human/boards-committees/> to determine which Research Ethics Board (REB) your proposal should be submitted.

4. LOCATION(S) WHERE THE RESEARCH WILL BE CONDUCTED:

If the research is to be conducted at a site requiring administrative approval/consent (e.g. in a school), please include all draft administrative consent letters. It is the responsibility of the researcher to determine what other means of approval are required, and to obtain approval prior to starting the project.

University of Toronto ☐
 Hospital ☐ specify site(s)
 School board or community agency ☐ specify site(s)
 Community within the GTA ☐ specify site(s)
 International ☐ specify site(s)
 Other ☒ Post-secondary classrooms in Second Life's virtual environment

The University of Toronto has an agreement with the Toronto Academic Health Sciences Network (TAHSN) hospitals regarding ethics review of hospital-based research where the University plays a peripheral role. Based on this agreement, certain hospital-based research may not require ethics review at the University of Toronto. If your research is based at a TAHSN hospital please consult the following document to determine whether or not your research requires review at the University of Toronto. <http://www.research.utoronto.ca/for-researchers-administrators/ethics/human/at-a-glance/where-to-apply-tahsn-institutions/>

5. OTHER RESEARCH ETHICS BOARD APPROVAL(S)

(a) Does the research involve another institution or site? Yes ☒ No ☐

(b) Has any other REB approved this project? Yes ☐ No ☒

If **Yes**, please provide a copy of the approval letter upon submission of this application.

If **No**, will any other REB be asked for approval?

Yes ☐ (please specify which REB) No ☒

Please note that REB approvals from other sites must be submitted to the ORE at U of T

6. FUNDING OF THE PROJECT

(a) Please check one:

Funded ☐	Agency:	Fund #: 4 (6 digits)
	Agency:	Fund #: 4 (6 digits)
Applied for funding ☐	Agency:	Submission date:
	Agency:	Submission date:
Unfunded ☒		
If unfunded, please provide an explanation why no funding is needed?		
This is my M.A. thesis research and is being conducted to fulfill degree requirements. Access to Second Life is free and does not require funding.		

If one protocol is to cover more than one grant, please include all fund numbers:

(b) If waiting for funding, do you wish to postdate ethics approval to the release of funds?

Yes ☐ No ☐

(c) For funded research, will more than one protocol be submitted to cover all research funded by the respective grant? Yes ☐ No ☐

Please list these protocols by title and RIS # (if known):

7. CONTRACTS

Is there a University of Toronto funding or non-funded agreement associated with the research?

Yes ☐ No ☒

If Yes, please include a copy of the agreement upon submission of this application.

Is there any aspect of the contract that could put any member of the research team in a potential conflict of interest? Yes ☐ No ☒

If yes, please elaborate under #10.

8. PROJECT START AND END DATES

Estimated start date for this project: September 2011

Estimated completion of involvement of human participants for this project: January 2012

9. SCHOLARLY REVIEW

(Please note: for submissions to the **HIV REB** from community investigators, scientific review is a pre-requisite for ethics review. If your study is unfunded, please contact the OHTN to arrange a scientific review prior to completing your ethics submission.)

Please check one:

X The research has been approved by a thesis committee or equivalent (required for thesis research)

☐ The research has undergone scholarly review prior to this submission for ethics review
(Specify review committee – e.g., departmental research committee, CIHR peer-review committee, OHTN scientific review, etc)

☐ The research will undergo scholarly review prior to funding
(Specify review committee – e.g., departmental research committee, CIHR peer-review committee, OHTN scientific review, etc)

☐ The research will not undergo scholarly review

10. CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

(a) Will the researcher(s), members of the research team, and/or their partners or immediate family members:

(i) Receive any personal benefits (e.g. financial benefit such as remuneration, intellectual property rights, rights of employment, consultancies, board membership, share ownership, stock options, etc.) as a result of or in connection to this study? Yes ☐ No ☒

(ii) If **Yes**, please describe the benefits below. (Do not include conference and travel expense coverage, or other benefits which are standard to the conduct of research.)

(b) Describe any restrictions regarding access to or disclosure of information (during or at the end of the study) that has been placed on the investigator(s). This includes controls placed by sponsor, funding body, advisory or steering committee.

There are no restrictions regarding access to or disclosure of information. I will be observing virtual classrooms both in and out of operation, and my role and objectives will be made explicit to designers, instructors, and students through the consent form.

(c) Where relevant, please explain any pre-existing relationship between the researcher(s) and the researched (e.g. instructor-student; manager-employee; minister-congregant). Please pay special attention to relationships in which there may be a power differential.

Research will be done in classrooms and with designers and instructors with whom I have had no existing relationships.

(d) Please describe the decision-making processes for collaborative research studies. If Terms of Reference exist, please attach them.

Not applicable.

SECTION B – SUMMARY OF THE PROPOSED RESEARCH

11. RATIONALE

Describe the purpose and scholarly rationale for the proposed project, and, if relevant, the hypotheses/research questions to be examined. The rationale for doing the study must be clear.

Distance education has, in its varied forms, provided an alternative to formalized learning within physical institutions for individuals who would otherwise be constrained by finance, geography, and lifestyle. A recent development in distance education technology has been the appropriation of “massively multiplayer,” persistent, immersive virtual environments (such as Second Life) for use as classroom spaces by post-secondary institutions. Instructors, architects, and often students have the opportunity to design learning spaces free of traditional physical and institutional restrictions, such as cost, acoustics, or gravity, yet these freedoms must (or may) be balanced with knowledge gained from environmental psychology and studies in building effective traditional learning environments. The scope of virtual classrooms being designed and used is not well established in the literature, nor are the insights and principles used by instructors and architects experienced in designing these environments easily accessible for subsequent research or application. It is the hope of this project to showcase examples of virtual learning environments built in Second Life, the design principles of their architects, and extant literature on virtual and traditional classroom design which speaks to these choices.

12. METHODS

Please describe all formal and informal procedures to be used. Describe the data to be gathered, where and how they will be obtained and analyzed. If research includes intentions to publish in other than standard academic venues, please indicate.

Research will take the form of a virtual ethnographic study of extant virtual classrooms in Second Life, both in and out of operation, including naturalistic observation, **surveys**, and semi-structured interviews. Virtual ethnography is increasingly being used to investigate online experiences, particularly in immersive environments such as Second Life. I will be working with **up to** four course instructors and whatever number of students agree to participate. Because there is no existing literature in this area, questions and observations will be focused for the instructors on the grounds for design and instructional decisions made, and for the students, on the nature of their experiences in the virtual immersive context in relation to other online or face-to-face learning contexts.

Attach a copy of all questionnaires, interview guides or other non-standard test instruments.

Please include a **list of appendices** here for all additional materials submitted (e.g., Appendix A – Informed Consent; Appendix B – Interview Guide, etc.):

(Please find attached **seven** documents in total.)

Recruitment Documentation

- Second Life Immersive Education Group Solicitation
- Email to Respondents

Letters of Information and Informed Consent

- For Instructors
- For Students (**updated**)

Questionnaires

- For Instructors
- **For Students**

Survey

- **For Students**

13. PARTICIPANTS OR DATA SUBJECTS

(a) Describe the participants to be recruited, or the subjects about whom personally identifiable information will be collected. Where recruitment is required, please describe inclusion and exclusion criteria. Where the research involves extraction or collection of personally identifiable information, please describe from whom the information will be obtained and what it will include. Strategies for recruitment are to be described in section #15.

- Instructors teaching and designing postsecondary classrooms in Second Life.
- Students currently taking classes in postsecondary classrooms in Second Life

Recruitment of instructors will be prioritized on number of courses taught in Second Life. Via the consent form, participating instructors will have the opportunity to decide whether they wish to be personally identified in my thesis, and to what extent (instructor name, institution name, course name, number of courses taught).

Recruitment of students will be randomized across those taking courses taught by participating instructors. Students will be linked to the course in question, but personally identifiable information beyond their completed letters of informed consent will not be collected and no personally identifiable information of any kind will be included in the thesis.

(b) Is there any group or individual-level vulnerability related to the research that needs to be mitigated (for example, difficulties understanding informed consent, history of exploitation by researchers, power differential between the researcher and the potential participant)?

No.

14. EXPERIENCE

(a) Please provide a brief description of (i) the principal investigator's, (ii) the research team's and (iii) the people who will have contact with the participants' experience with this type of research. If there has not been previous experience, please describe how the individual/team will be prepared.

The principal investigator has several years' experience navigating virtual immersive environments (including Second Life), as well as varied physical classroom experience both as a student and a teacher during practica and volunteering. As a result, the principal investigator also has fairly extensive informal experience discussing with instructors, administrators, and students the design principles and day-to-day construction of their learning environments.

The principal investigator has limited experience conducting ethnographic research, and will be coached by his thesis advisor.

(b) For projects that will involve community members (for example, Peer Researchers) in the collection and/or analysis of data, please describe their status within the research team (e.g. are they considered employees, volunteers or participants?) and what kind of training they will receive.

Not applicable.

15. RECRUITMENT

Where there is recruitment, please describe how, by whom, and from where the participants will be recruited. Where participant observation is to be used, please explain the form of insertion of the researcher into the research setting (e.g. living in a community, visiting on a bi-weekly basis, attending organized functions). Please make it explicit where it is reasonable to anticipate that all or some of the participants who will be recruited will not speak English or will speak English as a second language. Describe any translation of recruitment materials, how this will occur and whether or not those people responsible for recruitment will speak the language of the participants.

Attach a copy of all posters, advertisements, flyers, letters, e-mail text, or telephone scripts to be used for recruitment. This copy should be exactly as it will appear for recruitment.

Participating instructors will be recruited by the principal investigator initially through the Immersive Education, Distance Educators, Educators New to SL, and Real Life Education in Second Life user groups in Second Life, and then by word of mouth to colleagues of those members. Specifically, for this snowball recruitment method participating instructors will be invited to forward my initial recruitment message or give my institutional email address to colleagues who might be interested in participating; all respondents will be

sent the "Email to Respondents" message (see appendix) regardless of whether they were contacted initially by me or by a colleague.

Participating students will be recruited only by participating instructors, using the provided Letter of Informed Consent for Student Participants.

16. COMPENSATION

(a) Will participants receive compensation for participation?

Financial	Yes	☐	No	☒
In-kind	Yes	☐	No	☒
Other	Yes	☐	No	☒

(b) If **Yes**, please provide details and justification for the amount or the value of the compensation offered.

(c) If **No**, please explain why compensation is not possible or appropriate.

The investigation will involve participants volunteering their time for interview or their spaces for examination and will not significantly impinge on their ability to operate.

(d) Where there is a withdrawal clause in the research procedure, if participants choose to withdraw, how will compensation be affected?

Participants can withdraw at any time. Because there is no compensation offered for participation, this is not applicable.

SECTION C –DESCRIPTION OF THE RISKS AND BENEFITS OF THE PROPOSED RESEARCH

17. POSSIBLE RISKS

Risks to participants as individuals or as members of a community may include:

(a) Physical risks (including any bodily contact or administration of any substance); Yes ☐ No ☒

(b) Psychological/emotional risks (feeling uncomfortable, embarrassed, anxious or upset); Yes ☐ No ☒

(c) Social risks (including possible loss of status, privacy and/or reputation); and/or Yes ☐ No ☒

(d) Legal risks (potential of apprehension or arrest or being identified as a member of a legally-compromised group). Yes ☐ No ☒

Please describe the risks involved in the study, and what steps will be taken to ensure that they will be managed and/or minimized.

There are no significant risks physical risks involved in this study because it will be conducted in an entirely online context.

There are no significant psychological/emotional risks involved in this study because interviews will be conducted in private and will involve open-ended questions with regard to design principles, involvement in building virtual classroom spaces, and learning experiences (see attached interview questions). **The surveys will be distributed to students who sign the letter of informed consent by the course instructor, and will solicit demographic information about student experience in immersive environments as well as feedback specific to tools and activities used in the course (see appendix). Students submitting the surveys will do so to my institutional email address.** All participants will be informed and reminded that they may decline to answer or terminate either interviews or their involvement in the study at any time with no consequences.

There are no significant social risks because all participating students will be anonymous or pseudonymously identified. Participating instructors will have complete and modular control over their degree of personal, course, and institutional anonymity, which they can specify should they have any concerns regarding status or reputation. Participating students will be anonymous or pseudonymous and will not be identifiable to their professors. Students will be made aware of how many of their fellows in a given course will also be participating, so that in cases where only one student in a particular course has volunteered to participate (and whose responses would therefore be obvious to his or her participating professor), an opportunity to withdraw will be reiterated.

There are no significant legal risks because no participant will be part of (or will need to identify her/himself as part of) a legally vulnerable or compromised group.

18. POSSIBLE BENEFITS

Discuss any potential direct benefits to the participants from their involvement in the project. Discuss any potential direct benefits to the community, including any capacity building which is integrated into the study design. Comment on the potential benefits to the scientific/scholarly community or society that would justify involvement of participants in this study.

- For participating instructors and their institutions, benefits include exposure and increased legitimization of Second Life and virtual, immersive classrooms in general as educational settings. **Additionally, anonymous student feedback about the effectiveness of specific design features in the environments studied will inform instructors' evaluation in subsequent modification of those environments.**
- For the broader scholarly community, this study seeks to expand knowledge of the varied design approaches and understandings developed by educational practitioners and students in these virtual environments.
- For the educational community in general, my hope is that insights reported and discussed in this study will inspire further awareness, adoption, experimentation, and improved practice with regard to using Second Life for developing and implementing distance education.

SECTION D – THE INFORMED CONSENT PROCESS

19. THE CONSENT PROCESS

Describe the process that will be used to obtain informed consent. Please note that it is the quality of the consent, not the format that is important. If the research involves extraction or collection of personally identifiable information from a research participant, please describe how consent from the individuals or authorization from the data custodian will be obtained. If there will be no written consent, please provide a rationale for oral or implied consent (e.g., discipline, cultural appropriateness, etc.) and explain how consent will be recorded.

For information about the required elements in the information letter and consent form, please refer to <http://www.research.utoronto.ca/wp-content/uploads/2010/01/GUIDE-FOR-INFORMED-CONSENT-April-2010.pdf>

Where applicable, please attach a copy of the Information Letter/Consent Form, the content of any telephone script, screening materials, introductory letters, letters of administrative consent or authorization and/or any other material which will be used in the informed consent process. If any of the information collected in the screening process - prior to full informed consent to participate in the study - is to be retained from those who are excluded or refuse to participate in the study, please describe how those individuals will be informed of this.

No information collected during the screening and recruitment process will be retained.

The attached consent forms will be delivered to potential participants after their interest has been expressed during initial recruitment. Participating instructors will select the granularity of information they permit the thesis to report in terms of instructor name, institution name, and course name.

Participating students will be given consent forms by their participating instructors after the purpose and research methods have been explained. No personally identifiable information from students will be collected at any time.

Any participant may withdraw from the study at any time, for any reason. If an instructor withdraws, all participating students in his or her course will automatically be withdrawn.

20. COMMUNITY AND/OR ORGANIZATIONAL CONSENT, OR CONSENT BY AN AUTHORIZED PARTY

(a) If the research is taking place within a recognized community or an organization which requires that formal consent be sought prior to the involvement of individual participants, explain whether consent from that community/organization will be sought. Describe this consent process and attach any relevant documentation. If consent will not be sought, please provide a justification and describe any alternative forms of consultation that may take place.

The Immersive Education, Distance Educators, Educators New to SL, and Real Life Education in Second Life community groups in Second Life are leaderless, opt-in communities of professionals and academics which do not have formal infrastructures capable of processing official requests for consent to consult and recruit their members. Any member (myself included) is freely capable of broadcasting to other members currently online and can be individually “muted” by other members through their preferences interface. Therefore, official consent to broadcast my recruitment material cannot be meaningfully pursued.

The institutions or organizations to which individual participating instructors belong may have specific requirements for formal consent or demonstration of ethical oversight; participating instructors will be requested to direct me to the appropriate channels so that specific requirements can be discovered and met.

(a) If any or all of the participants are children and/or are not competent to consent, describe the process by which capacity/competency will be assessed, the proposed alternate source of consent - including any permission/information letter to be provided to the person(s) providing the alternate consent – as well as the assent process for participants.

Not applicable.

21. DEBRIEFING and DISSEMINATION

(a) If deception or intentional non-disclosure will be used in the research study, please justify. Please consult [Guidelines for the Use of Deception and Debriefing in Research](#)

Not applicable.

Please provide a copy of the written debriefing form, if applicable.

Not applicable.

(b) Will participants and/or communities be given the option of withdrawing their data following the debriefing? Please explain.

Not applicable. The participants can withdraw their data at any time.

(c) Please explain what information/feedback will be provided to participants and/or communities after their participation in the project is complete. (e.g., report, poster presentation, pamphlet, etc.)

Participants will be sent a link to the uploaded thesis on T-Space at the conclusion of the project.

22. PARTICIPANT WITHDRAWAL

(a) Where applicable, please describe how the participants will be informed of their right to withdraw from the project. Outline the procedures which will be followed to allow them to exercise this right.

Participants will be informed of their right to withdraw in the Letter of Informed Consent form(attached), where they will be instructed to send a written request to my institutional email informing me. I will delete all information associated with the withdrawing participants and send confirmation as a reply email.

(b) Indicate what will be done with the participant's data and any consequences which withdrawal may have on the participant.

At their request, data of withdrawing participants will be deleted (this will be explicitly offered upon withdrawal, and will be indicated in the Letter of Informed Consent). Withdrawal will have no consequences on the participant. If the participant is an instructor of students who are also participating, those students will be immediately withdrawn from the study.

(c) If participants will not have the right to withdraw from the project at all, or beyond a certain point, please explain. Ensure this information is included in the consent process.

Not applicable.

SECTION E –CONFIDENTIALITY AND PRIVACY

23. CONFIDENTIALITY

(a) Will the data be treated as confidential? Yes ☒ No ☐

(b) Describe the procedures to be used to protect anonymity of participants or informants, where applicable, or the confidentiality of data during the conduct of research and dissemination of results. Data security measures must be consistent with UT's [Data Security Standards for Personally Identifiable and Other Confidential Data in Research](http://www.utoronto.ca/security/UTORprotect/encryption_guidelines.htm). All identifiable electronic data outside of a secure server environment must be encrypted, consistent with the standards described at: http://www.utoronto.ca/security/UTORprotect/encryption_guidelines.htm.

Anonymity of participants will be ensured by the substitution of identifying names from automatically recorded logs with codes, and all references to participants within the finished document will retain this convention with the exception of those instructors who explicitly waive their anonymity in the Letter of Informed Consent (students cannot waive their anonymity). A reference document indicating which coded names correspond to which participants will be retained for the duration of the research so that the data provided by any participant who wishes subsequently to withdraw can be deleted. All data and participant-related materials (interviews, consent forms, the reference key described above) will be kept on my desktop computer within a virtual drive image encrypted with TrueCrypt 7.1 in accordance with the Encryption Guidelines document linked above. All correspondence with participants will be conducted through my institutional email address with no forwarding to any other email address.

(c) Describe any limitations to protecting the confidentiality of participants whether due to the law, the methods used or other reasons (e.g., duty to report)

Not Applicable

(d) Explain how written records, video/audio recordings, artifacts and questionnaires will be secured, how long they will be retained, and provide details of their final disposal or storage. Describe the standard data security procedures for your discipline and provide a justification if you intend to store your data for an indefinite length of time. If the data may have archival value, discuss this and whether participants will be informed of this possibility during the consent process.

All data will be kept securely in a locked filing cabinet in the case of handwritten notes. Please see Section 23(b) of this document for details as to the storage of digital materials. Physical and digital data records will be kept for 5 years and then destroyed by deletion in the case of online copies and shredding at the University in the case of paper materials. These are standard procedures in Educational research.

(d) If participant anonymity or confidentiality is not appropriate to this research project, please explain. Also, explain how identifiable data in written records, video/audio recordings, artifacts, questionnaires, etc. will be secured.

Identifiable data in the research materials, such as signatures on letters of informed consent, names associated with pseudonyms in the reference key (see 23(b) of this protocol), and voices in recorded audio interview files, will be secured if in physical form within a locked filing cabinet in the principal researcher's home, or digitally in a virtual drive image encrypted with TrueCrypt 7.1 on my personal desktop computer.

24. PRIVACY REGULATIONS

For research involving extraction or collection of personally identifiable information, provincial, national and/or international laws may apply. I will report any apparent mishandling of personally identifiable information to the Office of Research Ethics. **My signature as Principal Investigator, in Section G of this protocol form, confirms that I am aware of, understand and will comply with all relevant laws governing the collection and use of personally identifiable information in research.**

SECTION F – CONTINUING REVIEW OF ONGOING RESEARCH

RISK MATRIX: REVIEW TYPE BY GROUP VULNERABILITY AND RESEARCH RISK –check one:

Research Risk			
Group Vulnerability	Low	Medium	High
Low	1 ☒	1 ☐	2 ☐
Medium	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐
High	2 ☐	3 ☐	3 ☐

See the [Instructions for Ethics Review Protocol Submission Form](#) for detailed information about the Risk Matrix.

Explain/justify the level of risk and group vulnerability reported above:

There are not aspects of the research that are kept from participants. The object of the study is to gain veridical accounts of their experiences. Thus participants are in control of what they choose to divulge to the researcher. The experiences under discussion are not typically emotionally charged or contentious, but are rather educational experiences. Thus overall, the participants are not in high risk categories and nor are the experiences to be discussed.

Review Type

Based on the level of risk, these are the types of review that a protocol may receive:

Risk level= 1: Delegated Review (formerly expedited); Risk level = 2 or 3: Full Board Review

For both delegated and full reviews (SSH&E, HS, or HIV REB), please submit one electronic copy of your protocol and appendices (e.g., recruitment, information/consent and debriefing materials, and study instruments) as a **single** Word document or a pdf. Please ensure that the electronic signatures are in place and e-mail to new.ethics.protocols@utoronto.ca

All other submissions, which are not new (e.g., revisions and continuing review submissions), as well as general inquiries, should be sent to ethics.review@utoronto.ca

The deadline for delegated review (SSH&E or HS) is EVERY Monday, or first business day of the week, by 4 pm. HIV REB reviews all protocols at full board level but applies proportionate review based on the level of risk.

REB meeting and submission due dates are posted on our website ([SSH&E](#), [HS](#) or [HIV](#)).

Please note that the final determination of Review Type and level of monitoring will be made by the University of Toronto REB and the Office of Research Ethics.

SECTION G – SIGNATURES

The faculty supervisor/sponsor and his/her respective Departmental Chair/Dean or designate must sign below:

As the **Investigator** on this project, my signature confirms that I will ensure that all procedures performed under the project will be conducted in accordance with all relevant University, provincial, national and international policies and regulations that govern research involving human participants. I understand that if

there is any significant deviation from the project as originally approved I must submit an amendment to the Research Ethics Board for approval prior to its implementation.

For U of T **student researchers**, my signature confirms that I am a registered student in good standing with the University of Toronto. My project has been reviewed and approved by my advisory committee (where applicable). If my status as a student changes, I will inform the Office of Research Ethics.

Signature of Investigator: 

Date: May 1, 2012

***For **Graduate Students**, the signature of the Faculty Supervisor is required. For **Post-Doctoral Fellows** and **Visiting Professors or Researchers**, the signature of the Faculty Sponsor is required. ***

As the **Faculty Supervisor** of this project, my signature confirms that I have reviewed and approve the scientific merit of the research project and this ethics protocol submission. I will provide the necessary supervision to the student researcher throughout the project, to ensure that all procedures performed under the research project will be conducted in accordance with relevant University, provincial, national or international policies and regulations that govern research involving human subjects. This includes ensuring that the level of risk inherent to the project is managed by the level of research experience that the student has, combined with the extent of oversight that will be provided by the Faculty Supervisor and/or On-site Supervisor.

As the **Faculty Sponsor** for this project, my signature confirms that I have reviewed and approve of the research project and will assume responsibility, as the University representative, for this research project. I will ensure that all procedures performed under the project will be conducted in accordance with all relevant University, provincial, national or international policies and regulations that govern research involving human participants.

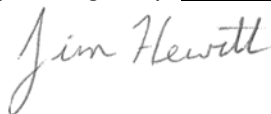
Signature of Faculty Supervisor/Sponsor: Date: May 1, 2012



As the **Departmental Chair/Dean**, my signature confirms that I am aware of the proposed activity and that it has received appropriate review prior to submission. My administrative unit will follow guidelines and procedures which ensure compliance with all relevant University, provincial, national or international policies and regulations that govern research involving human subjects. My signature also reflects the willingness of the department, faculty or division to administer the research funds, if there are any, in accordance with University, regulatory agency and sponsor agency policies.

Print Name of Departmental Chair/Dean (or designate): Jim Hewitt, Associate Chair, CTL

Signature of Departmental Chair/Dean:
(or designate)



Date: May 1, 2012

Appendices

Recruitment Documentation

Second Life Education User Groups Solicitation

(This message is sent to members of the group who are currently online and is not retained nor received by members who are not online. This message will be sent several times over a period of a few days to reach different members of the Second Life community groups.)

I'm sorry to bother you, folks. If you've got a second, I'm an M.A. student at the University of Toronto (OISE) looking to record interviews with post-secondary educators who have taught or are currently teaching courses in Second Life classrooms. If you'd consider volunteering about an hour of your time to speak/chat with me and show me around your classroom (and help me survive my thesis), please email me at danny.fekete@utoronto.ca and I can send you details and profuse gratitude. (Also, if you know other instructors who might be interested in participating, please consider forwarding this message.) – Danny

Email to Respondents

(The message below will follow a brief personal expression of gratitude for the respondent's interest.)

This is explained in greater detail in the attached letter of informed consent, but briefly, I'm looking to conduct interviews with post-secondary educators and (if willing/interested) their students currently teaching and learning in classes conducted wholly or chiefly in Second Life. My area of interest is classroom design principles—how are educators and their students making use of customizable, immersive environments that aren't subject to traditional limitations of physical institutional space, what kinds of limitations are imposed by working in a virtual environment, and how are those obstacles are being dealt with?

My research is designed as ethnography, so optimally I'd observe your class in operation, but failing that, I'd be grateful for the opportunity to have a tour of your space and/or be able to ask you some questions about your design processes and experiences teaching in Second Life.

My hope is that this research will provide a cohesive document to describe some of the innovation in immersive distance education, contextualize it within current research, and foster further inquiry and experimentation.

Thank you very, very much for your consideration. If you've got any questions for me, please feel free to reply to this message.

- Danny Fekete

Please note, I've attached the following:

1. **A Letter of Informed Consent for Participating Instructors.** This describes the research, how I'm hoping you'll participate, and provides information about confidentiality, ethics, and your rights as a participant.
2. **A Letter of Informed Consent for Participating Students.** If you'd consider letting me observe your class in progress and conduct interviews with students interested in participating, this is the form that you'd give your students to elicit their participation.
3. **Basic Questions for Student Interviews.** As part of the process of clearing my study with the Office of Research Ethics at OISE (ethics.review@utoronto.ca, 416-946-3273), this questionnaire has been approved for use with participating students. I've included it in this package to give you a sense of what I'd be asking them, with the understanding that, as part of the semi-structured interview format, I'll supplement or skip questions as appropriate to my observations. If these questions meet with your approval and you decide to send the letter of informed consent to your students, I'd ask that you not share these questions, as I'd prefer to conduct the interviews unrehearsed.

Letters of Information and Informed Consent

For Instructors

I am interested in understanding the issues around the design of immersive, virtual learning environments as they pertain to instructors' design principles and students' experiences. With growing access to broadband Internet and the falling price of graphically competent computers, technological barriers are disappearing to distance education involving "massively multiplayer" immersive environments. While the use of these environments by postsecondary institutions for credited courses is increasing, knowledge about how these spaces can best be designed and implemented remains limited to communities of veteran instructors and has not yet been the focus of the sort of systematic research and experimentation that we've seen with more traditional forms of distance education. Understanding and showcasing theory-informed design principles, the rules of thumb, and the insights of teachers and students building, teaching, and learning in this new environment will open up immersive distance education to a wider user base and will allow new teachers and students to benefit from the failures and successes of those who came before.

Second Life is a good place to do this because it's a widely-adopted and broadly available platform, its toolkit and interface are mature and polished, and Linden Labs seems interested in facilitating educational applications. Therefore, my thesis will involve an ethnographic (or "netnographic" (Crichton & Kinash, 2003)) study of instructors and students in credited courses conducted wholly or predominantly online within *Second Life*. My study will explore how *Second Life* spaces are being built and used, with a particular focus on the design feature or principles that you, as an instructor, employ in creating a virtual learning space, and how your students interact with and reconstruct that space. I am asking for your participation in the following ways:

1. The opportunity to visit an educational space that you've designed for your class so I can explore and describe its features.
2. A brief tour of that space where you can provide any context or insight you wish into your design process and how the space is currently being used.
3. Respond to a brief (half-hour to an hour) semi-structured interview to provide clarification on the above and to answer more general questions about your teaching in *Second Life*.
4. Optionally, permit me to observe one or more of your classes in session.
5. Optionally, extend the additional (attached) letter of consent to the students in the observed class, which asks permission to interview them with regard to their experiences learning in and interacting with the space you've designed, as well as general questions about their experiences of embodied learning in *Second Life*. (The general questions are also attached for your perusal, though if you consider forwarding my request to your students, I would ask that you *not* provide those questions to them ahead of time.)

The feedback that you and your students provide will be incorporated into my Master's Thesis as both narrative and to provide context to discussions of the literature. It is my hope that the insight you provide will contribute to knowledge about the variety of design philosophies and experiments currently underway in the development of immersive virtual learning environments, and to inspire further inquiry and experimentation.

Confidentiality

At your discretion (as indicated below), your name and the name of your institution will be represented anonymously. If any of your students wish to participate, they will be represented anonymously. Interviews conducted by text-based chat will have identifying information replaced by codes.

Recordings of interviews (audio and text) will be kept in an encrypted folder on my personal desktop computer for the duration of my thesis work and then five years thereafter, whereupon the data will be deleted. My thesis will be openly available for free digital download from the University of Toronto's online repository, T-Space, and from my personal website, Philomathy.org, for the foreseeable future.

Also, you may contact the Office of Research Ethics (ethics.review@utoronto.ca, 416 946 3273) if you have questions about your rights as a participant.

Signature and Permissions:

I understand that I may withdraw my permission at any time, with no consequences and without providing a reason, by contacting me at danny.fekete@utoronto.ca or by calling me at 647 654 7396.

I agree to allow my online data and interview responses to be used as part of the research described above. I understand that these data will be used in accordance with the anonymity rules I choose below, and that if I do not specify any rules, these data will be completely anonymous by default.

Name: _____ Date: _____

I wish to make the following information available for the researcher to use in the body of the text (understanding that if I take no action here, by default all information will remain anonymous).

Please check all that apply:

- ☐ My name
- ☐ The name of my course
- ☐ The name of my institution

Works Cited:

Crichton, S., & Kinash, S. (2003). Virtual Ethnography: Interactive Interviewing Online as Method. *Canadian Journal of Learning and Technology*, 29 (2). <<http://www.cjlt.ca/index.php/cjlt/article/view/40/37>>

For Students

Dear students of [instructor's] course,

This letter is to invite you to participate in research I'm conducting to conclude my M.A. thesis work at the University of Toronto (Ontario Institute for Studies in Education). My interest is in how teachers and students design and use immersive virtual learning spaces for distance education. I think this is an important area for study because, while there's been a lot of research, debate, and experimentation in order to design optimal *physical* classrooms and the guidelines for how they're used, the same is not yet true for *virtual* classrooms, which may have unusual limitations like what kind of computer and internet connection is available to you as a student, or alternatively, can escape many traditional limitations, like pre-bought furniture and displays, keeping layout friendly for subsequent instructors and their classes, and gravity. Because this kind of research isn't readily available to teachers and students, each new virtual classroom designer has a number of wheels to reinvent; my hope is that with my thesis, I'll be building a document that will use your experiences in *Second Life* to contribute to a resource for future online learners and instructors.

[Your instructor] has already given me permission to explore your classroom and has talked with me about design from [his/her] perspective. My hope, however, is to also get input from you about what it's like to learn in a virtual world—the ways you use *Second Life*, what works and what doesn't, and how things could be improved. If you're willing, I'm asking for your participation in the following ways:

1. **I'd like to send you a short questionnaire to collect demographic data about what kind of student you are, what your prior and concurrent experience has been with Second Life, immersive environments, and technology in general, etc. The survey would be sent to you by [your teacher]---at no time will I require any of your contact details beyond what I already have as a member of the class group.**
2. The opportunity for me to interview you, one-on-one, for about half an hour. This would be a chance for me to ask you directly about your experiences and opinions, and to build on what I've seen while your class is operating. The interview would be conducted in *Second Life* via text or audio chat, or over *Skype* (whichever works best for you), and would be recorded so I could review it. **(If you'd prefer to use Skype, I'll need your contact information for that service.)**

The feedback you and [your teacher] provide will be incorporated into my Master's thesis as both narrative descriptions and to provide context to discussions of what researchers are talking about currently in distance education. It is my hope that these insights will contribute to knowledge about the variety of design philosophies and experiments currently underway in the development of immersive virtual environments, and to inspire further inquiry and experimentation.

Confidentiality

At your teacher's discretion, [he/she] will be identified by name and may identify your institution or course name, but you will be completely anonymous.

Recordings of interviews (audio and text) will be kept in an encrypted folder on my personal desktop computer for the duration of my thesis work and then five years thereafter, whereupon the data will be deleted. When it's finished, my thesis will be openly available for free digital download from the University of Toronto's online repository, T-Space, and from my personal website, Philomathy.org, for the foreseeable future.

Also, you may contact the Office of Research Ethics (ethics.review@utoronto.ca, 416 946 3273) if you have questions about your rights as a participant.

Signature:

I understand that I may withdraw my permission at any time, with no consequences and without providing a reason, by contacting me at danny.fekete@utoronto.ca or by calling me at 647 654 7396.

I understand that my decision to participate or not has no bearing whatsoever on my marks in this class.

I agree to allow my online data and interview responses to be used as part of the research described above. I understand that these data will be used anonymously.

Name: _____

Date: _____

Questionnaires For Instructors

Introductory Questions:

1. Name:
2. Institution for which the course is currently being taught:
3. Roughly how many years have you been teaching professionally, and in what contexts?
 - a. (If unanswered above) How many courses have you taught in *Second Life* before this one?
4. What is the name of the course you're currently teaching in *Second Life*?
 - a. Could you provide a brief description of the course? (Discipline, mandatory/elective, open/closed, number of students)
 - b. Are you currently teaching or have you previously taught this course in any context (face to face, distance via any media including *Second Life*)?
 - c. (If applicable) What sort of differences do you notice between students taking your courses online as opposed to in a traditional classroom? (Age, full-time/part-time, technological comfort, private commitments, social engagement, etc.)
5. Why is this course being offered within *Second Life* rather than (or in addition to) face to face, or in another online form?
 - a. (Was this your decision, and if so why?)

Design Principles for Building in *Second Life*:

6. What kinds of physical and social features contribute to an effective learning environment? (What contributes to the teaching context, what does effective mean to the instructor?)
7. How would you describe the differences between preparing a classroom space in a traditional face-to-face context with your experience in *Second Life*? (Flexibility, affordances, limitations.)
 - a. As compared with building or working within a physical learning environment, what sort of limitations are there to the space you have in *Second Life* in terms of design and usage?
8. Please describe the process of preparing a learning environment in *Second Life* from first being assigned to teach a course through to the first meeting with your students.
 - a. What do you take into account when designing a learning space in SL (and why)?
 - b. How, if at all, does (or has) the space change(d) throughout the course?
 - c. What sort of access and privileges (or rules and limitations) do your students have within the space? (Change the environment, set up models/presentations, etc.)
 - i. How are these distinct from other *Second Life* users?
 - ii. (If applicable) In what ways if any are these different from those experienced by your students in traditional, face-to-face environments?
 - d. What does the space look like when a class isn't in session? (Do students or others spend time there?)
9. What, if anything, governs the aesthetic decisions you make when designing or implementing a learning space in *Second Life*? (Traditional classrooms, availability of 3D resources, modifications to previous spaces, course content/subject area, personal or learner tastes and interests?)

Students within *Second Life* Classrooms:

10. In what ways do students interact differently with your *Second Life* classroom space than they do with your traditional, face-to-face classroom space?
11. What proportion of their scheduled meeting time do your students spend in environments you've designed for that class?

- a. Where else do they spend their time?
 - b. If any, what sorts of asynchronous activity take place within the environment?
12. If you've taught more than one course in *Second Life*, how have the learning environments you've used and designed changed between courses, and what do you think drove those changes?

For Students
(Please note, this document has been wholly amended.)

***Second Life* Student Questionnaire**

Thank you very much for agreeing to participate in this survey. The purpose of the survey is to collect data about what kinds of students use *Second Life* in what ways, and to give Dr. Gasior anonymous feedback on the effectiveness of his teaching objects and activities. If you indicate that you'd like to meet for an interview (at the end of the survey), I'll be using your responses here to avoid asking repetitive questions; the information you provide will otherwise be completely anonymous in the body of my thesis.

Please feel free to skip any of the questions for any reason.

1. Have you spent more than three years out of school since you graduated from high school?
☐ Yes
☐ No
2. Do you regularly use *Second Life* for any reason other than attending this course?
☐ Yes
☐ No
3. Do you use any applications other than *Second Life* during the lecture? (eg. Browsers, Skype, note-taking software, PowerPoint, music, etc?) Please list any that you regularly have open.
4. Where do you tend to be, physically, when you connect to *Second Life* to attend a scheduled class meeting? (Please check any that apply.)
☐ On campus (computer lab, classroom, lounge, coffee shop, etc., please specify)

☐ At home
☐ At work (off-campus)
☐ It varies (please elaborate)
5. How often do you watch the optional videos or listen to optional audio programs left out by the instructor before and after class? (Please check any that apply.)

☐ I watch all of the videos	☐ I listen to all of the audio
☐ I watch videos when they interest me	☐ I listen to audio when it interests me
☐ I rarely watch the videos	☐ I rarely listen to the audio
☐ I don't watch the videos	☐ I don't listen to the audio
☐ I couldn't get the videos to work	☐ I listened to the radio programs
	☐ I listened to the recorded lectures
	☐ I couldn't get the audio to work
6. Have you ever consulted tutorial materials in Moodle or Dr. Gasior's YouTube channel?
☐ All of them
☐ Sometimes, when I needed them

☐ Never

7. Have you friended any of the other students from the class, either with *Second Life* or another program (Skype, Facebook, shared email addresses, etc?)

☐ Yes
☐ No

8. If it wasn't a matter of convenience, are there any reasons you'd take a course in *Second Life* again, if the same course was offered in person? (If so, please specify here.)

9. Do you control the camera in *Second Life* independently of moving your avatar? (Please check one.)

☐ Frequently
☐ Only if where I'm sitting or standing makes it hard to see things
☐ Not really
☐ I didn't know I could do that

10. (The following question is intended to give Dr. Gasior feedback on the specific tools he developed during this course. We'll go into a bit more depth during the interview.) Did the *Second Life*-specific learning objects or activities help you learn the topics better than you feel you could have by reading and lecture alone?

Please rate each tool or activity from 1 to 5, where, compared with using the textbook/lecture:

1 = this activity made it tedious and difficult to learn the subject matter

2 = this activity made it tedious to learn the subject matter

3 = This activity was about the same

4 = this activity made it more interesting to learn the subject matter

5 = this activity made it more interesting and easier to learn the subject matter

Activity/Tool	Rating (1-5)
Chemistry valence shells and ball-and-stick molecule construction	
Mitosis/Meiosis chromosome segregation objects	
Population genetics and selection globe	
Bunny breeding and pedigree analysis	
Animal poster construction and presentation	

When you've finished this survey, please email it to danny.fekete@utoronto.ca

If you wish to be contacted for the interview, please leave your name below and I'll send you an instant message in *Second Life* to arrange a time that would be convenient for you. Otherwise, thank you very, very much for taking the time to help me, and best of luck with your finals.

- Danny Fekete

☐ I wish to be contacted for a half-hour interview about my experiences as a student in Second Life. My name in Second Life is _____.

Open-Ended Interview Questions (to be discussed in real-time)

Introductory Questions:

1. Before this course, what sort of experience did you have with online worlds, *Second Life* or otherwise? (Describe your experiences in immersive, 3D environments—gaming, research/modeling, simulations, single/multiplayer/MMO)
 - a. (Possible followup:) Have you taken a course in *Second Life* before?
2. Roughly how much time did you first spend working on your Avatar in *Second Life*?
 - a. Have you changed your Avatar since you started the course? (How/why?)
 - b. Why do you sit? Do you care where you sit? (If applicable: Do you ever sit next to friends?)

Learning in Second Life:

3. How do your interactions with fellow students in *Second Life* compare with other students face-to-face? (Regularity, openness, trust, confidence/shyness, frequency.)
4. Please describe a typical session in your second life course, from logging on to logging off. (Pre/post-session engagement/socializing; time spent where, doing what?)
 - a. (If applicable) Do you ever visit the classroom on days or at times outside of class time? (Why?)
 - b. What does communication look like between you and the other students/instructors (are there asynchronous elements like messages, blogging etc., does everyone use a headset/type, how is communication organized when everyone's talking at once)
 - i. (If applicable) Do you use features like group chat, IM, whispering, or voice? When do you tend to use messaging other than local chat?
 - ii. Have you ever had a comment or question you wanted to raise during a lecture, but then decided not to? (For what reasons? If you've been typing out a question and then stopped, why?)
 - iii. If you were allowed to use voice chat during the lecture, would you prefer to use that rather than text-chat?
5. When in *Second Life*, what elements of the virtual environment do you interact with, and how?
 - a. In what ways are these interactions different than what you would do in a physical learning environment, and for what reasons? (Differing control over common environment, different resources/permissions/affordances/limitations?)
6. (For specific activities that scored low on the survey) You indicated that [the activity] didn't help your learning/got in the way of your learning. Would you be willing to elaborate on why it was a bad fit? (Manipulation of objects, technical issues like connectivity/software/etc., inexperience/stress, unclear instructions, gimmicky, etc?)



UNIVERSITY OF
TORONTO

OFFICE OF THE VICE PRESIDENT, RESEARCH

PROTOCOL REFERENCE # 26904

May 11, 2012

Dr. M. Clare Brett
DEPT OF CURRICULUM, TEACHING &
LEARNING
OISE/UT

Mr. Daniel Fekete
DEPT OF CURRICULUM, TEACHING &
LEARNING
OISE/UT

Dear Dr. Brett and Mr. Daniel Fekete,

Re: Your research protocol entitled, "An ethnography of classroom designs in second life and other immersive 3D virtual learning environments"

We are writing to advise you that a member of the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Ethics Board (REB) has granted approval to an amendment (Received May 3, 2012) to the above-referenced research protocol under the REB's delegated review process.

Any changes to the approved protocol or consent materials must be reviewed and approved through the amendment process prior to its implementation. Any adverse or unanticipated events should be reported to the Office of Research Ethics as soon as possible.

Best wishes for the successful completion of your research.

Yours sincerely,

Margaret Schneider, Ph.D.,
C.Psych
REB Chair

Dean Sharpe, Ph.D.
REB Manager

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